

Formal Reconstruction And Conviction Formation

Stefan Kober

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Reading

Read the following. While reading, observe how convictions emerge, change, or disappear.

Let

$$x = 0.\overline{9}$$

Multiply both sides by 10.

$$10x = 9.\overline{9}$$

Since $9.\overline{9} = 9 + 0.\overline{9}$, we can write:

$$10x = 9 + 0.\overline{9}$$

Since $x = 0.\overline{9}$, we can substitute x :

$$10x = 9 + x$$

Subtract x from both sides.

$$9x = 9$$

Divide by 9.

$$x = 1$$

Since $x = 0.\overline{9}$ and $x = 1$:

$$0.\overline{9} = 1$$

Now read the following. While reading, observe how convictions emerge, change, or disappear.

Like to the falling of a star,
Or as the flights of eagles are,
Or like the fresh spring's gaudy hue,
Or silver drops of morning dew,
Or like a wind that chafes the flood,
Or bubbles which on water stood:
Even such is man, whose borrowed light
Is straight called in, and paid to night.
The wind blows out, the bubble dies;
The spring entombed in autumn lies;
The dew dries up, the star is shot;
The flight is past, and man forgot.

[*Sic Vita* by Henry King (1592-1669)]

Observing

The proof may have seemed immediately convincing. Or suspicious despite each step appearing to work. A deduction steps can be checked carefully. A particular transformation may attract attention. The conclusion may resist even when the intermediate steps do not. If the result is already known, the derivation can be followed with little resistance.

In the poem, mortality may become salient. An image may captivate. The repeated movement from appearance to disappearance may be noticed. A memory may surface, or a phrase may connect with something already important. The poem may be read for its sound, its images, or its thought. Or it may not become interesting at all.

In the proof, we can examine the derivation itself.

A line can be revisited, a substitution questioned. The relation between one step and the next can be retraced after the first reading has passed. This is reconstruction in a narrower sense.

It may not recover what happened while reading the proof. What it does recover is the dependency that leads from the initial expression to the conclusion.

The poem can also be examined. The text remains there to return to. Its syntax, rhythm, imagery, repetitions, and contrasts can be studied, as can its historical setting and relation to other poems. Parts of its structure can be reconstructed.

But what became important while reading or hearing it may involve more than those relations. This becomes especially clear when a poem is spoken by a human voice for a human ear. Pace, emphasis, pauses, and voice can change what comes forward.

What happens in either case does not belong to the proof or poem alone. It arises between what is encountered and what is already present in orientation.

In the proof, reconstruction lets us retrace how the conclusion follows from the initial expression.

In the poem, reconstruction can recover parts of the text's structure. It may not recover what became important in the encounter, and may even counteract it.

This does not divide the two examples, still less texts in general, into a proof that is reconstructed and a poem that is experienced. A proof may be accepted with little attention to its derivation, while a poem may be examined in considerable structural detail. What counts as a proof, and what counts as a poem, have both taken different forms, and many texts combine features that invite different kinds of examination. Both are encountered within an existing orientation.

A Wider View

This essay is a recursive examination of a possible lesson one could draw from Conviction Formation Theory.

Its Part II spent a great deal of time showing what formal systems can do. They can expose dependencies, stabilize distinctions, and generate constraint once enough is fixed.

That result is real.

But precisely because this worked so well, another conviction can arise: formal reconstruction is the only defensible way to participate in conviction formation.

Yet nothing so far has established that claim, and CFT gives us little reason to expect it.

One of the practical consequences of CFT is that inquiry does not have to wait until every standard by which we judge it has itself been finally settled. We can work with what currently carries enough force, examine it further when it becomes questionable, and sometimes hold parts of it fixed while examining something else.

CFT recasts the question “Which standards are finally justified enough to authorize all the others?” into a more workable one:

“Given what convinces me now, what can I examine, what can I hold fixed for the moment, and what can I make available for further examination?”

Formal systems are especially good at making some of these relations explicit.

But defensible participation need not be formal.

Questions, comparisons, examples, practices, experiences, stories, and many other things can participate in changing what becomes salient, what possibilities become available, and what eventually becomes convincing. What becomes convincing can still be defensible.

A poem need not work like a proof. A meditation need not work like an argument. Conversations can redirect attention without producing a conclusion. Memories can reorganize a question without stating a premise. An image can make

something difficult to ignore without showing that it follows from anything. An experience can alter a conviction before we can say what changed. A perception can reorganize how a situation appears. Unease can arise without presenting an argument for itself.

None of this has to take the form of a formal reconstruction before it can matter to conviction formation.

That does not place it beyond examination.

We can ask what different forms of participation bring into play, what they make available for further examination, what standards we use in judging them, and what remains obscure.

They too can become objects of recursive examination.